

Fifteen Days That Were Never Small



Some people measure love in years.

We measured ours in ordinary days.

Fifteen of them.

If you only looked at the calendar, you'd probably think nothing extraordinary could happen in such a short time. Fifteen days isn't enough to know someone. It isn't enough to build a life. It certainly isn't enough to change one.

And maybe you're right.

But calendars only count days.

They don't count conversations.

They don't count laughter that makes your stomach hurt.

They don't count "Good morning" messages that quietly become part of your routine.

They don't count a child running toward someone she barely knows and deciding, all on her own, that she feels safe enough to kiss on the cheek.

Calendars don't know how to count those things.

So let me tell you our story instead.

Not because it lasted.

Because it mattered.



We didn't begin with fireworks.

We began with replies.

One message became another.

One joke became an inside joke.

One "Take care" became "Have you eaten?"

We talked on Discord.

Then Facebook.

Sometimes voice calls.

Sometimes in person.

Eventually, the platform stopped mattering.

It was never about where we talked.

It was always about finding another reason not to stop.

Looking back now, I can't even remember which conversation happened where.

I only remember how it felt.

Warm.

Easy.

Comfortable.

Like meeting someone who made it feel safe to simply be myself.



Some people fall in love because of grand moments.

I fell in love because of ordinary ones.

The way she'd tell me about her day.

The way she'd suddenly disappear because one of her children needed her.

The way conversations would pause — not because interest disappeared, but because life happened.

I never felt like I was competing with her children.

I wanted to become someone worthy of standing beside all of them.

When people asked if three children were a deal breaker, I honestly couldn't understand the question.

Deal breaker?

No.

Blessings.

That's the word I used.

And I meant it.



Somewhere between the jokes and the coffee, we started talking about things that sounded dangerously permanent.

Apartments.

Separate rooms for the kids.

December.

Rings.

Marriage.

The future.

None of those conversations felt unrealistic at the time.

They felt...

possible.

That's probably why those conversations stayed with me.

They weren't fantasies.

They were ordinary enough to feel real.

Not because I lost an apartment.

Not because I never bought the ring.

Because I lost the future I had already started furnishing inside my head.



People sometimes ask me what I miss most.

They assume it's the relationship.

It isn't.

It's a moment.

One afternoon, her eldest daughter ran toward me without hesitation and kissed me on the cheek.

No one told her to do it.

No one asked her to.

She simply decided that I was safe.

I've experienced romantic love before.

I've experienced heartbreak before.

But that...

That was different.

There was something so pure about being accepted by a child who owed me nothing.

I don't know if I'll ever experience that exact feeling again.

But I know I'll spend the rest of my life hoping I do.



If this chapter had ended with "happily ever after," it would've been easier to write.

It didn't.

It ended with silence.

Then questions.

Then a goodbye that arrived through a screen instead of across a table.

I won't pretend I understood everything.

Maybe I never will.

There are still questions whose answers belong only to her.

I've stopped trying to invent them.

Instead, I've started accepting my own.

Because sometimes healing isn't finding the missing page.

Sometimes it's learning to continue reading even without it.



People have asked me if I regret those fifteen days.

I don't.

If someone offered me the chance to erase them to avoid the pain that followed, I'd refuse.

Immediately.

Because sadness doesn't erase happiness.

It proves happiness happened.

Those fifteen days taught me that I could still love after years of believing I couldn't.

They reminded me that I still had dreams worth making.

They showed me the kind of partner I wanted to become.

And maybe...

that's enough.



Years from now, I probably won't remember every message.

I won't remember every joke.

I won't remember whether something happened on Facebook or Discord.

Memory doesn't work that way.

But I'll remember how peaceful it felt to imagine a future with someone.

I'll remember children laughing.

I'll remember coffee.

I'll remember planning apartments that were never built.

I'll remember a kiss on my cheek from a little girl who changed me without knowing it.

Most of all...

I'll remember that for fifteen days...

I loved completely.

And I think that's something worth carrying with me for the rest of my life.

Some people measure love in years.

I still measure ours in fifteen unforgettable days.



— Ralph.

